

feature, I began frantically stockpiling again, but I didn't enjoy it as much as I once had. When my son Matt moved out, our household consisted of just four females, hardly the size of family I'd always needed to stockpile for. I unplugged my basement freezer and filled totes full of peanut butter and cereal for the cupboards of my college son's first apartment.

Negatives aside, I have also seen how couponing can benefit one's own family, as well as others. As a stay-at-home mother of several children, I used coupons to stretch our thin budget. That feat gave me a great deal of satisfaction. My well-stocked cupboards had always been a source of pride for me, as have my Christmas gifts and baskets and the prize baskets I put together for my couponing workshops. I've also been able to donate to food banks and put together boxes of health and beauty items for families in need, when I might not have been able to otherwise. Presenting couponing workshops helped me see how much I enjoyed public speaking and teaching, second only to my love of writing. Couponing has been a huge part of my life, and I will always remain a deal seeker. I've gradually begun using coupons again, but not to the degree I used to.

Who exactly are the extreme couponers? Obviously, the answer isn't that easy. We can no more pigeonhole the avid couponer than we can the families that choose homeschooling. Saying that all homeschoolers are fundamentalist Christians turns out to be just as untrue as labeling extreme couponers as hoarders. Many of the couponers I spoke with didn't even have stockpiles, and some donated nearly everything they obtained free to charities. It turned out the only thing I could count on in my interviews was that love of talking about our shopping adventures. There are no hidden